

Chapter 1

Title

Authorname

Abstract

Diachronic paths to uninflectedness in South Slavic¹

Alexander Krasovitsky, Maria Kyuseva, Matthew Baerman, Greville G. Corbett

We argue that the ongoing loss of case in Serbian and Bulgarian dialects has led to a split system with competing co-grammars: one where nouns inflect and another where they do not. This division between "forerunners" (without inflection) and "underachievers" (with inflection) results in partial rules of different kinds. There are three types of splits depending on the dialect. First, a split between morphological classes, where some retain case distinctions while others do not. Second, classes that retain inflection may still exhibit uninflectedness in specific constructions, such as partitive constructions. Third, an otherwise inflecting morphological class may split on a semantic basis, such as human vs. non-human. These asymmetries in morphological change lead to the rise of partial synchronic rules, whether morphological, syntactic, or semantic. These rules persist over time and evolve as historical processes move into new phases. By studying these rules in contemporary dialects and arranging them chronologically, we can uncover the detailed stages of this historical process.

• Introduction

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The loss of inflectional case marking is an ongoing process in the dialect continuum that stretches across Serbian and Bulgarian linguistic territory. This has led to substantial variation in the dialect case systems of the region. We observe the first signs of this historical change in systems with rich case distinctions, where case marking is obligatory on all classes of nominals, as in the western part of the continuum. Further east, we find dramatically reduced case paradigms, with just a few distinct case forms, attested with only part of the lexicon, while the rest of the lexicon has lost the ability to inflect for case. At the same time, in these dialects we find competing rules of case marking, which appear to reflect different historical periods in the breakdown of the case system. The result is either competition between more or less distinct inflection (towards the west, in Serbian dialects), or competition between inflection and uninflectedness (towards the east, in Bulgarian dialects). We investigate factors which underlie this competition and show how they vary at different stages of this case decline. This provides us with an insight into the historical mechanisms underlying case loss, and to the conditions that may foster this change.

While our analysis has confirmed the relevance of the factors previously proposed to explain variable case marking synchronically and diachronically (e. g. **Moravcsik1978; Bossong1991; König2008; DalrympleNikolaeva2011; Cristofaro2013; Kurumada, & Jaeger2015; Witzlack-MakarevichSeržant2018; SeržantWitzlack-Makarevich2018**), the data obtained from Serbian and Bulgarian dialects shed new light on these factors and show that they do not in fact operate in the way that has previously been suggested.

First, extensive typological data show explicit case marking is used in environments where it is essential to avoid ambiguity (e.g. between subjects and objects) and is omitted where syntactic roles are transparent (**Comrie1977**). For example, it has been shown that the omission of morphological case marking goes hand-in-hand with the use of adpositions, which to a certain extent duplicate the information conveyed by case inflection. This has been shown to play a role in diachronic processes affecting case systems: the information redundancy of case inflection in adpositional constructions may make these constructions more prone to the loss of morphological case than those without adpositions, where case inflection provides critical information about syntactic roles (**HewsonBubenik2006**). In the dialects of East Serbia, while the use of adpositions (prepositions) correlates with a decline in case distinctions, the dialects display a pattern which is the opposite of what is predicted by the above principle: the original case marking is better preserved precisely when governed by a preposition, and more prone to loss elsewhere.

Second, pragmatic requirements, in particular discourse salience, have been proved to be another important factor in variable case marking cross-linguistically. To mention just two examples, **McGregor2018** and **Montaut2018** present somewhat similar situations in unrelated languages (Southern African Khoisan and Dravidian respectively) where the rise of object case marking led to pragmatically motivated choices between overt case marking (accusative) and zero marking: prominent objects receive overt case marking while backgrounded objects do not. In Bulgarian border-region dialects, where just two cases have been preserved (nominative and accusative), explicit case marking on non-subject nouns (accusative) is also conditioned by pragmatic factors. However, it is not associated with pragmatic salience, but rather the opposite: explicit (accusative) marking on non-subjects is more frequent in pragmatically less prominent parts of an utterance (e.g. containing background information). Pragmatic prominence instead tends to trigger nominative marking on non-subject nouns, which makes them morphologically indistinguishable from subjects.

We present two case studies that show how different factors shape the transition from a larger to a smaller case system, and further to uninflectedness. After the essential background information in §??, we consider the role of structural factors, which are dominant in Serbian dialects (§??), and analyse the impact of pragmatic conditions, which are dominant in Bulgarian dialects under study (§??). We suggest that this shift in prominence is due to the diachronic stage each variety has reached: structural factors are prominent at earlier stages of case decline and pragmatic factors at an advanced stage.

• Background

South Slavic varieties inherited from Proto-Slavic a case system with six morphological cases (plus the vocative whose status as case is debatable²) and six major inflection classes (**Mirčev1958**: 147-160, **Slavova2017**: 127-178, **Popović1955**: 115). The further history of case largely correlates with the division of the South Slavic territory into eastern and western zones. In the western zone (contemporary Serbian, Croatian, Bosnian, Montenegrin, Slovenian) the original Proto-Slavic case system has been largely preserved. In the eastern zone (contemporary Bulgarian and Macedonian), most varieties have seen the reduction and loss of nominal case marking and the rise of analytical constructions (e.g. prepositional

²Vocative forms continue to be widely used in contemporary Serbian and Bulgarian, but do not express grammatical relationships (**Blake2004**) and do not interact with the types of configurations we have investigated.

constructions), as can be seen by contrasting the data from standard Bulgarian and standard Serbian in Table ??³.

Standard inflected forms	Serbian:	Standard prepositional with an form	Bulgarian: phrases uninflected	Translation
ovo je Kipar (nomina- tive)		tova e Kipâr		‘This is Cyprus’
idu na Kipar (ac- cusative)		otivat na Kipâr		‘They go to Cyprus’
pomažu Kipru (dative)		pomagat na Kipâr		‘They help Cyprus’
stanovništvo Kipra (genitive)		naselenieto na Kipâr		‘The population of Cyprus’
žive na Kipru (locative)		živejat na Kipâr		‘They live in Cyprus’
upravljaju Kiprom (in- strumental)		upravljavat Kipâr		‘They govern Cyprus’

Table 1: Nominal inflection in Serbian and corresponding forms in Bulgarian

In between these two types there is a substantial transitional zone. A characteristic feature of these dialects is the competition between these two strategies, as seen both in Serbian (??) and Bulgarian dialects (??)⁴.

1. *Zove ga otac telefon-om / na telefon*

call[PRS.3SG] 3SG.M.ACC father[NOM] phone-INS.SG on phone[ACC](=NOM) ‘The father calls him by phone’ (Miloradović2002: 183; 202)

2. *Petr-a / Petâr go njama*

³Bulgarian and Macedonian demonstrate an asymmetry between nominal and pronominal systems with respect to case marking. Nouns and adjectives do not inflect for case (in standard varieties and in a significant number of dialects). Personal pronouns distinguish full and clitic forms (the choice being syntactically determined). Full personal pronouns retain a two-case distinction, nominative vs. accusative, the latter being used in all non-subject syntactic roles: *tja* (3SG.F.NOM) *običa* (‘she loves’) vs. *običam neja* (3SG.F.ACC) (‘I love her’) vs. *kazax na neja* (3SG.F.ACC) (‘I told her’, literally ‘to her’). Clitic personal pronouns are used in non-subject roles and distinguish between accusative and dative: *običam ja* (3SG.F.ACC) vs. *kazax i* (3SG.F.DAT) (‘I told her’).

⁴For interlinear glosses, we follow the conventions of the Leipzig Glossing Rules (<https://www.eva.mpg.de/lingua/pdf/Glossing-Rules.pdf>) with the following additions: AOR – aorist, EXIST – existential, IMPF – imperfect.

Peter-SG.ACC / Peter[SG.NOM] 3SG.M.ACC EXIST.NEG
 ‘Peter is absent’ (Stojkov1981)

The dialects in this transitional area correspond to different postulated chronological stages of the decline of the Proto-Slavic case system. A group of dialects in the west of the transitional area preserve all six original Proto-Slavic cases (plus vocative), but speakers regularly replace three of them with the accusative form, which serves as a general oblique case (Table ??, Transitional system 1). Thus, the original six-case system competes in these dialects with an innovative three-case system, consisting of nominative, dative, and accusative only (Miloradović2003; Simić1972). The further east one goes, the greater are the reductions. The dative case is the next to be replaced (Transitional system 2). Here, the more conservative three-case system competes with a two-case system, consisting of nominative and accusative (Belić1905, Ivić1956). Finally, in the east of the transitional area, the accusative itself starts to yield to a single uninflected form (Transitional System 3). Here, the two-case system coexists with a system without case (Stojkov1975, Stojkov1981). Thus, three structural dialect types can be distinguished within the transitional area, according to the size of the case paradigm: six-, three- and two-case systems, as summarised in Table ??.

Table 2: Case systems in the Serbian-Bulgarian dialect continuum^a

The chronology that this transition reflects has been reconstructed primarily on the basis of liturgical texts produced within various regional written traditions in the South Slavic territory from the 10th century onwards (Tsonev1984; Duridanov1956, Duridanov1958; Rusek1964; Češko1970; Belić1905) and, for later periods, on the basis of clerical and household documents (Bernštejn1948).

It is believed that the decay of the case system originated in the South Slavic eastern zone (Bulgarian and Macedonian) around the 10th century (Duridanov1958). By the end of the 14th century morphological case marking on nominals was completely lost in at least in some of the dialects spoken in the eastern zone (Bulgarian border-region dialects) (Češko1970). Even earlier, by the end of the 13th century, case loss was at an advanced stage in a number of Macedonian dialects (Rusek1964). In Serbian, the process of case decline started sometime before the 12th century and affected the South-East dialects (Belić1905). It did not, however, lead to the complete loss of case distinctions: rather it resulted in different types of reduced systems.

Historical evidence points to the following processes involved in this change: the spread of prepositional constructions replacing bare noun phrases; the redistribution of functions between indirect cases and displacement of less productive

indirect cases; the spread of accusative forms in the function of an oblique case generalising across original indirect cases⁵; and the spread of uninflected forms replacing this oblique case.

- **Constructional variation: the loss of the genitive in Serbian dialects**

The loss of case in European languages has been reported to go hand in hand with the increased use of prepositions (Blake2004; HewsonBubenik2006; Kulikov2006). Blake2004 illustrates this with an Old English version of Luke 15:15 (??) and Wyclif's fourteenth-century translation (??) (glossing and translation are as in Blake2004):

3a. *He folgode an-um burg-sitt-end-um menn thaes rices*

he followed one-DAT town-dwell-ing-DAT man.DAT that.GEN land.GEN

3b. *He clevede [=attached himself] to oon of the citizens of that contré*

'He hired himself out to one of the citizens of that country.'

In (??), the directional ('to the citizen') and the possessive ('of this country') relationships are expressed via inflection, while in (??), they are expressed by prepositional constructions. The relationship between the two processes, however, is not clear. Did the spread of prepositional constructions cause case to disappear as it became semantically redundant (as claimed in Hjelmslev1935; HewsonBubenik2006)? Or was it, by contrast, a repair strategy necessary after the loss of explicit case marking, as proposed, for example, in Skautrup1944?

The variation found in Serbian dialects allows us to investigate the interplay of inflectional case marking and prepositional constructions using synchronic data. We focus here on the genitive, which is in the process of being replaced by the accusative. Specifically, we ask: do prepositional constructions particularly favour this replacement? This is what an informativeness principle would predict: since the preposition provides semantic context, genitive case marking is redundant and the more general accusative case can be used without any loss of information (cf. Comrie1977, Comrie1989). Our data, however, show the opposite tendency: prepositional constructions favour the *retention* of the genitive, while its replacement by the accusative is more advanced in non-prepositional contexts. That means that in Serbian dialects, some principle other than informativeness is at play. At this point in our investigations we are unable to identify

⁵The chronology of the displacement of individual indirect cases varies. The most stable, as dialectological data of the Serbian language show (Belić1905, Miloradović2003) is the dative case. The historical data from Bulgarian also testify to this: the dative forms of nouns were found in Bulgarian texts of the 17th, 18th and even 19th centuries, while the genitive, instrumental and local cases had already fallen out of use in Bulgarian dialects in the 13th-14th centuries (Mirčev1958: 255-260; Češko 1970: 301-310).

what this could be, so our goal here is to provide evidence which might spur further research.

In §??, we introduce the data used in this case study. §?? outlines the use of the genitive forms in Serbian and discusses the results of previous research on the variation between genitive and accusative in South-East Serbian dialects. Sections 3.3 and 3.4 present the patterns of variation found in our data; §?? discusses the theoretical implications of our findings.

3.1. Data

The data for this study come from sociolinguistic interviews with speakers of Serbian dialects located in or near Kosovo. These come from two sources: the archive of the Institute for Balkan Studies and our own fieldwork. The archive provided a subset of recordings collected in the project “Research of Slavic Vernaculars in Kosovo and Metohija” (2002 – 2003) led by the Institute for the Serbian Language of SASA and financed by UNESCO. Our data come from fieldwork in the municipality of Brus, Central Serbia, conducted by Maria Kyuseva within the project “Declining case: inflectional loss in progress” in 2022.

These data were collected in a uniform fashion that conforms to the Serbian dialectological tradition. The participants were native speakers of local dialects, aged between 70 and 81 years, who had been long-term residents of the region and had engaged in traditional activities throughout their lives, such as cattle breeding or agriculture. This sampling ensured the minimal interference of the high-prestige standardised variety of Serbian. The topics of the interviews included history, tradition, culture, crafts, cuisine, everyday life, and biographical stories.

The total corpus compiled from these two sources contains over 274,800 tokens, 30 hours and 36 minutes of recordings. Overall, twenty-three speakers from eleven villages were recorded. Figure ?? shows the locations of the villages, which are colour-coded according to dialect. The Zeta-South Sandžak dialect is marked in green, the Kosovo-Resava dialect is marked in pink, and the Prizren-South Morava dialect is marked in purple.

Zeta-South Sandžak Kosovo-Resava Prizren-Timok

With respect to case marking, these three dialects have the same system (Transitional System 1 in Table ??): all six original cases are preserved to various degrees, but three of them (genitive, locative, and instrumental) can be replaced by accusative forms. The dialects differ in the frequency of such replacements. Zeta-South Sandžak is the most conservative: it has a stable six-case system, and the three peripheral cases are only occasionally replaced by the accusative. Kosovo-Resava represents a more advanced stage of case loss: the genitive, locative, and instrumental cases frequently give way to the accusative. Finally, Prizren-South

Figure 1: Locations of the interviews in Serbia

^aIn distinguishing between the largely syncretic dative and locative cases in Serbian, we follow the Slavic tradition of case description (Piper, Klajn2013, Miloradović2003). The non-syncretic locative endings were used at least until the end of the 15th century (Belić1999), while the loss of case started sometime before the 12th century (Belić1905). It thus that when the process of the case loss started, the dative and locative were still morphologically distinct cases. An additional argument in favour of differentiating between the two cases comes from the fact that it facilitates the description of the process of the case loss. The original locative case is frequently replaced by the general oblique in the whole transitional area, including the western region where it is the only case to be replaced. The original dative case, on the contrary, is preserved in most Serbian dialects with the exception of the eastern zone where the only remaining cases are nominative and accusative (Sobolev1991).

Morava shows the most advanced stage: the locative and instrumental are virtually non-existent (occurring with only a handful of lexemes), and the use of genitive is highly restricted. We compare the usage of genitive forms in these three dialects and project the synchronic tendencies onto the diachronic plane. This allows us to draw conclusions regarding the historical dynamics involved in the decline of this case.

3.2. Genitive case in Serbian

The Serbian genitive is highly polysemous. Its typical function is to mark a relationship between two entities, such as possessor-possessee, part-whole, and source-goal. Additionally, it can denote time, reason, goal, and manner. From the point of view of syntax, it has a wide distribution. It can be used in adnominal, adjectival, and verbal constructions, as well as in prepositional constructions and constructions with a quantifier. Out of all the cases, the genitive occurs with the widest inventory of prepositions (Feleško1955).

Various studies of individual dialects of South-East Serbia have already established the heterogeneous behaviour of the genitive in different constructions. For example, Miloradović2003 analyses the competition between the genitive and accusative in the Kosovo-Resava dialect of the Paraćin region in Central Serbia. She observes that while the genitive is dominant in prepositional constructions, its use is highly limited elsewhere. In verbal constructions, the genitive is replaced by the accusative (??), in adnominal constructions – by a prepositional phrase (??), and in adjectival constructions, it can be replaced either by the accusative or by a prepositional phrase (??).

4a. *nije bi-l-o vod-e* -> *nije bi-l-o vod-u*

AUX.NEG.3SG be-PTCP-N.SG water-GEN.SG AUX.NEG.3SG be-PTCP-N.SG water-ACC.SG
'There was no water'

4b. *kraj mačug-e* -> *kraj od mačug-e*

end[NOM.SG] cane-GEN.SG end[NOM.SG] of cane-GEN.SG

‘Cane end’

4c. *pun vod-e* -> *pun vod-u*

full[M.NOM.SG] water-GEN.SG full[M.NOM.SG] water-ACC.SG

pun s vod-u

full[M.NOM.SG] with water-ACC.SG

‘[It is] full of water’

Stanković²⁰²² analyses the speech of the younger population in the town of Vranje in South Serbia, where the Prizren-South Morava dialect is spoken. This dialect has a three-case system consisting of the nominative, accusative, and dative. The speech of the younger generation, however, is influenced by the standard dialect. Therefore, it is susceptible to the penetration of other cases found in the standard, especially the genitive. Stanković observes that the possibility of using the genitive depends on the construction. Focusing on the non-prepositional uses, she finds that adnominal constructions and constructions with a numeral permit the occasional appearance of the genitive case (5a-b), while constructions where the complement depends on a verb or a predicative adjective do not (5c-d):

5a. *udic-a za pecanj-e rib-a*

rod-NOM.SG for catching-ACC.SG fish-GEN.PL

‘Fishing rod’

5b. *ima-m pet različit-ih igar-a*

have-PRS.1SG five different-GEN.PL game-GEN.PL

‘I have five different games’

5c. *nije je-o čokolad-u* / **čokolad-e*

AUX.NEG.3SG eat-PTCP.M.SG chocolate-ACC.SG / *chocolate-GEN.SG

‘He didn’t eat the chocolate’

5d. *dvorišt-e pun-o s igračk-e* / **pun-o igračak-a*

yard-NOM.SG full-N.NOM.SG with toy-ACC.PL / *full-N.NOM.SG toy-GEN.PL

‘The yard is full of toys’

In our study, we bring these individual observations together by comparing the use of the genitive case forms in different constructions across the three South-East Serbian dialects: Zeta-South Sandžak, Kosovo-Resava, and Prizren-South Morava.

3.3. Constructions with the genitive in South-East Serbian

We focus on three constructions with the genitive case: prepositional constructions, constructions with a quantifier, and adnominal constructions. In South-East Serbian dialects, these constructions allow both the original genitive and the innovative accusative forms:

6. Prepositional construction:

6a. *napravljen-i od drv-a*

made-M.NOM.PL from wood-GEN.SG

‘[They are] made from wood’

6b. *ima i od drv-o*

EXIST.PRS and from wood-ACC.SG

‘There is [some of it] from wood as well’

7. Construction with a quantifier:

7a. *malo trav-e gi stavi-m*

a.little grass-GEN.SG 3PL.DAT put-PRS.1SG

‘I put a bit of grass for them’

7b. *i ondak turi malo trav-u*

and then put[IMP] a.little grass-ACC.SG

‘And then put a little bit of grass’

8. Adnominal construction:

8a. *tamo odnese-š čaš-u vin-a*

there take.away-PRS.2SG cup-ACC.SG wine-GEN.SG

‘You take there a cup of wine’

8b. *i uzme-š čaš-u vin-o*

and take-PRS.2SG cup-ACC.SG wine-ACC.SG

‘And you take a cup of wine’

The overall number of examples in the dataset is 960. The prepositional construction is represented by 676 examples, the adnominal construction – by 169 examples, and the construction with a quantifier – by 115 examples. The ratio represents the occurrence of these constructions in spontaneous speech. For the prepositional construction, we include only phrases with the preposition *od* ‘from, of’, which is the most frequent preposition that governs the genitive. Constructions with a quantifier include the following quantifiers: *mnogo* ‘a lot’, *malo* ‘a little’, *lek* ‘very little’, *pomalo* ‘a little bit’, *puno* ‘much’, *više* ‘more’, and *manje* ‘less’. Finally, adnominal constructions include a variety of governing nouns, the most frequent meanings in the sample are: “quantity” (a cup of tea, a bowl of rice), and “part-whole” (top of the table, edge of the village). True possession (a son of my brother), otherwise typical for the construction, is rare in our examples. It is usually expressed in the dialects by alternative means of expression, such as possessive adjectives and constructions with the dative case.

The bar chart (Figure ??) shows the variation between the original genitive and the innovative accusative in the three dialects.

As the figure illustrates, in Zeta-South Sandžak (the leftmost section of the bar chart), the most conservative dialect in the sample, the genitive prevails in all

Figure 2: Competing strategies of case marking in South-East Serbian dialects

three constructions. It appears in 90% or more of the examples in the prepositional and adnominal constructions and is used somewhat less in the construction with a quantifier. As the ANOVA⁶ test shows, there is no significant effect of the construction on the case in this dialect, with $p=0.2429$ and $F = 1.4284$. The difference between the three constructions is more prominent in the Kosovo-Resava dialect, which has a more advanced stage of case decline. Here, the genitive still dominates with 90% of occurrences in the prepositional construction, it concedes slightly in the adnominal construction, and its use falls dramatically in the construction with a quantifier, where it is no longer a dominant strategy. The ANOVA test shows a significant effect of the construction on the case in this dialect with $p=3.3092e-18$ and $F=44.1388$. Finally, the most innovative Prizren-South Morava dialect (the rightmost section of the bar chart) shows yet another picture. Here, the use of accusative is the dominant strategy in both the adnominal construction (65% of examples) and the construction with a quantifier (92% of examples), and the only construction where the genitive appears in a slight majority of examples (56%) is the prepositional construction. Again, ANOVA shows a significant effect of the construction with $p=1.1018e-06$ and $F=14.2548$. (The null hypothesis for each of three dialects assumed no effect of the construction on case selection.)

These data show that the use of the genitive versus the accusative in the Serbian dialects under study is at least partly conditioned by the type of construction. The exact conditions depend on the dialect, The exact conditions depend on the dialect, or if we accept the diachronic interpretation of the data, on the stage of case decline. The general tendency is the following: constructions with a quantifier are the most susceptible to the penetration of the innovative accusative, adnominal constructions come second, and prepositional constructions preserve the original genitive the longest. This effect is clear when we look at the distribution of cases in individual dialects, but it can also be seen if we trace the linguistic behaviour of the constructions across dialects. The use of the genitive case consistently declines in each construction as we move across the transitional zone from west to east. For each construction, we find a significant effect of the dialect: with $p=2.1082e-25$ and $F=61.8976$ (prepositional construction), $p=9.1127e-10$ and $F=23.6043$ (adnominal construction), and $p=1.1889e-06$ and $F=15.4478$ (construction with a quantifier).

⁶The ANOVA analysis of the corpus data here and below was carried out by Dr Alexander Stewart (University of St Andrews, UK).

3.4. Morphologically conditioned variation in Serbian dialects

Another factor that conditions variation between the original genitive and innovative accusative case is the inflection class. This plays a role in the whole dialectal continuum, but in our data it is especially pronounced in the Prizren-South Morava dialect.

In standard Serbian, nouns cluster into four inflection classes (Table ??). The paradigms exhibit a high degree of syncretism (see the comment in footnote 5 concerning dative – locative syncretic forms).

Inflection class II: kuća ‘house’ feminine (some masculine)				Inflection class III: stvar ‘thing’ feminine				Inflection class IV: polje ‘field’ neuter			
SG	PL	SG	PL	SG	PL	SG	PL	SG	PL	SG	PL
NOM	prostor	prostor-i	kuć-a	kuć-e	stvar	stvar-i	polj-e	polj-a			
ACC	prostor	prostor-e	kuć-u	kuć-e	stvar	stvar-i	polj-e	polj-a			
GEN	prostor-a	prostor-ā	kuć-e	kuć-ā	stvar-i	stvar-ī	polj-a	polj-ā			
DAT	prostor-u	prostor-ima	kuć-i	kuć-ama	stvar-i	stvar-ima	polj-u	polj-ima			
LOC	prostor-u	prostor-ima	kuć-i	kuć-ama	stvar-i	stvar-ima	polj-u	polj-ima			
INS	prostor-om	prostor-ima	kuć-om	kuć-ama	stvar-ju	stvar-ima	polj-em	polj-ima			

Table 3: Inflection classes in Serbian.

In South-East Serbian dialects, there is a tendency for nouns of inflection class III to adopt the forms (and the gender) of inflection class I. For this reason, we do not have enough examples to be able to draw reliable generalizations about this class, and we exclude it from further analysis. The bar chart below shows the variation between the genitive and the accusative for the remaining three inflection classes in the Prizren-South Morava dialect:

Figure 3: Prizren-South Morava dialect: original genitive vs. innovative accusative in different inflection classes

The choice of case is clearly conditioned by inflection class: class II favours the genitive form, while class I and class IV favour the accusative form. This pattern can be illustrated with examples of the same meaning of the genitive (material) being expressed differently depending on the inflection class:

- 9a. se ispred-e **od vun-e**
REFL spin-PRS.3SG from wool(II)-GEN.SG
‘It is spun from wool’

9b. pravi-l-i od drv-o

make-PTCP-M.PL from wood(IV)-ACC.SG

‘They used to make it from wood’

In (??), the noun belongs to class II (*vuna* ‘wool’) and takes the genitive; in (??) the noun belongs to class IV (*drvo* ‘wood’) and takes the accusative. This tendency to preserve the original case form in class II is even more pronounced in Bulgarian border-region dialects, where case marking is only possible with class II nouns (see §??).

3.5. Discussion: structural factors in case decline

These data illustrate both syntactic and morphological conditions on variation between the genitive and accusative. In terms of syntax, certain constructions favour the use of the accusative over the genitive, in particular prepositional phrases. In terms of morphology, certain inflection classes are more likely to adopt the innovative accusative, in particular class II.

The tendency of prepositional phrases to preserve the original case marking contradicts commonly held assumptions about the role played by prepositions in case loss (Blake2004; HewsonBubenik2006). Since genitive case marking in these prepositional constructions is semantically redundant, it could be omitted without incurring any ambiguity. One might assume then that prepositional constructions would be the first to lose the genitive. The fact that our data show the opposite means that the preservation of the genitive is not driven by the need to disambiguate. We propose here a possible alternative motivation.

Following Norde2002, we distinguish two types of less-effort strategies for grammatical change: a speaker-oriented and a hearer-oriented strategy. These can be thought of as two opposing forces that shape any language change. The speaker “wants” to make less effort in encoding the message, and the hearer “wants” to make less effort in decoding the message. The informativeness principle aligns with a hearer-oriented strategy. In this instance, the genitive should first be replaced in prepositional constructions, as it is not needed for the hearer to be able to correctly interpret the message, while it has a function in other constructions. A speaker-oriented strategy would be one that favours ease of production. The genitive case after the preposition *od* ‘from’ is syntactically determined: *od* governs the genitive, creating a high degree of predictability: every time the preposition *od* ‘from’ is used, it can be expected to be followed by the genitive. In adnominal constructions and constructions with a quantifier, there is no such syntactic determination, in the sense that the nouns, such as ‘cup’ or ‘edge’, do not obligatorily govern a noun phrase, and quantifiers can similarly be used on their own. In this way, the syntactic information supports the case

morphology and contributes to the preservation of the original case forms. Crucially, there is no gain for the hearer in preserving the case forms in prepositional constructions while omitting them in non-prepositional constructions. Rather, it is in the speaker's interest to keep an inflected form in a context that always requires it.

With these results in mind, we turn to the contrasting patterns of Bulgarian border-region dialects.

4. Competing case marking in Bulgarian border-region dialects: pragmatic factors

In Bulgarian border-region dialects, case marking is lost in all inflection classes of nouns except class II. In this class, singular nouns retain two case forms, nominative and accusative; plural forms are not inflected for case. The nominative marks nouns in the subject position and the accusative marks nouns in non-subject positions. Nouns in classes I, III and IV have retained only one (historically nominative) morphological form for each number value (singular and plural) which is used both in the subject and any non-subject position. This is illustrated in examples (??), (??), (??) and (??) from our corpus (data represent various locations in the municipalities of Belogradchik and Trân).

Inflection class I, masculine. Caseless (historically nominative)

10a.	<i>Dojde doktor.</i> Come[PST.3SG] doctor[SG] 'A doctor came.'	subject NP	Filipovtsi,
Trân			
10b.	<i>Izvika-me dok-</i> <i>tor.</i> call-PRS.1PL doc- tor[SG] 'We call a doctor.'	non-subject NP	Filipovtsi,
Trân			
10c.	<i>Tija babičk-i kak</i> <i>da otiva-t</i> this [NOM.PL.F] elderly.woman- NOM.PL how COMP go-PRS.3PL <i>na doktor?</i> to doctor[SG] 'How would these elderly women get to a doctor?'	non-subject PP	Gorni Lom, Belo- gradchik

Inflection class II, feminine and masculine. Nominative and accusative

11a.	<i>Vod-a gi e kara-l-</i> <i>a.</i> water-NOM.SG subject NP 3PL.DAT be.3SG transport-PTCP- SG.F 'Water moved them.'	Goren Chiflik, Belogradchik
11b.	<i>Sipe-mo vod-u.</i> pour- PRS.1PL water-ACC.SG 'We pour water.'	non-subject NP Repljana, Belo- gradchik
11c.	<i>Ide i za vod-u.</i> Go[PRS.3SG] and for water-ACC.SG 'And s/he is go- ing to get water.'	non-subject PP Gorni Lom, Belo- gradchik

Inflection class III, feminine. Caseless (historically nominative)

12a.	... sol <i>se posolva</i>salt[SG] REFL salt[PRS.3SG] '...salt is being added.'	subject NP	Salash, Belograd- chik
12b.	<i>Nasipe-m sol i</i> <i>ga* pritisne-š</i> . pour.in-PRS.1PL salt[SG] and 3SG.ACC press.down- PRS.2SG 'I pour in salt and one would press down.'	non-subject NP	Filipovtsi,
Trân 12c.	<i>Posolva-š sâs sol</i> . salt-PRS.2SG with salt[SG] . 'You add salt / one adds salt.'	non-subject PP	Salash, Belograd- chik

*Dialectal form corresponding to *go* in Standard Bulgarian.

Inflection class IV, neuter and masculine. Caseless (historically nominative)

13a.	... mlek-o se pod- sirva. ...milk-SG REFL ferment[PRS.3SG] '... milk is fer- mented.'	subject NP	Chuprene, Belo- gradchik
13b.	Ako ima-š mlek- o . if have-PRS.2SG milk-SG 'If you have milk.'	non-subject NP	Ezdimirtsi,
Trân			
13c.	Dve kofičk-i ot mlek-o . two pot-PL of milk-SG 'Two pots of milk.'	non-subject PP	Ezdimirtsi,
Trân			

The clear-cut distribution of the nominative and accusative across subject and non-subject positions within inflection class II as presented in (??), however, does not always hold in the border-region dialects. These dialects show a tendency to generalise the nominative for inflection class II nouns across non-subject positions (similar to Standard Bulgarian where this process has been completed in all historical inflection classes, **Mirčev**1958: 146-147). This results in competing choices for case marking on non-subject NPs and PPs as illustrated in (??) and (??) by examples from the corpus:

14a.	Vod-u gi dava- mo. water-ACC.SG 3PL.DAT give- PRS.1PL 'We give them water.'	non-subject (accusative)	NP	Repljana, Belo- gradchik
14b.	Vod-a smo kara- l-i. water-NOM.SG be[PRS.1PL] carry-PTCP-PL 'We used to carry/haul water.'	non-subject (nominative)	NP	Ezdimirtsi,
Trân				
15a.	<i>Ne može bez vod-</i> <i>u da peče-š.</i> NEG possible without water- ACC.SG COMP roast-PRS.2SG 'One can't roast [meat] without water.'	non-subject (accusative)	PP	Filipovtsi,
Trân				
15b.	<i>Da ne ostane bez</i> vod-a. COMP NEG re- main[PRS.3SG] without water- NOM.SG 'So that s/he won't be left without water.'	non-subject (nominative)	PP	Salash, Belograd- chik

From a diachronic perspective, the situation in Bulgarian border-region dialects